

Burlington College
Convocation
September 9, 2015

Schedule for Judith Orloff

- 9:00 – 9:30 a.m. Arrive at Burlington College
 Meet with Executive Team
- 10:30 a.m. Interview, Taylor Dobbs, VPR
- 11:00 a.m. ?? Logan Crawford WCAX w/ Carol Moore
- 12:00 – 1:30 p.m. Convocation
 Presentation from Judith: 12-15 minutes
 Reception to follow
- 2:15 p.m. Trustee Meeting
- 2:30 p.m. Interview with Jesse Kreitzer, BC Film & Media Dept.
- 4:00 p.m. Faculty, Staff, Student reception

Convocation Speech for 2015 Burlington College

- Like most of you, I have always questioned what I was told. I was searching for truth and wanted to make a difference in all I do. So, I went on a search
- Moved to Village and worked at Revlon and an ad agency
- Moved back to Philadelphia and worked at Horizon House, halfway house for community based mental patients.
- While working in the Presidents office at University of Pa. Where I met Stuart LaCasce who was on a mission to create a college in Burlington, Vermont. He asked me to join him.
- Offered this incredible opportunity, to unleash my creativity with a few other like-minded individuals, like George Burrill and Greg Guma to create an alternative college. WOW.
- Uprooted my two children and with food stamps and 800.00 moved to South Burlington.
 - Stuart believed in the ideals of John Dewey, born in 1859 in Burlington Vermont. Steward believed that education would lead to the ultimate ethical ideal of humanity. We

developed an educational structure that struck a balance of delivering knowledge while simultaneously teaching students to learn to use their gifts and talents for the greater good to create profound social change.

- With that in mind, it is not a surprise that the first class I taught was Male and Female in a Sexist Society, the students were prison guards, single moms, veterans and a few young alternative students searching for freedom.
- That was our beginning. Accreditation was always on our minds as well.

We are talking about 1972 and here we are in 2015. Four issues we faced then are still quite prevalent today.

Environmentalism:

- First earth day was 1970
- Inconvenient truth was 2010 – We still are in hot debate as to whether global warming is real.

Feminism

- Roe VS wade was passed by the Supreme Court in 1973
- Today, although the wage gap is lessening, issues such as rape culture, gender roles, and unrealistic body image are being confronted and open for discussion

LGBT

- Harvey Milk was elected to public office as mayor of San Francisco in 1977. Members of our school came out including Steward. Gay culture came into the public limelight
- Gay marriage was legalized in 2015, yet public elected officials are going to jail rather than issue licenses.
- Black Nationalist Movement grew out of frustrations with “non-violent strategies of earlier civil right’ Activists. And today we are face situations like Charleston and Ferguson and police being shot while getting gas or sitting in their vehicles. 60% of our prison population are African American males.
- **Veterans made up the largest population of our college in the 70’s. Many students are veterans today and, today veterans are committing suicide at the rate of 22 per day.**

Our mistakes:

Pounded on doors, blamed law enforcement, Wall Street, institutions were bad, etc. picketed. We couldn't be taken seriously.

We were coopted by people smarter than us. We became the corporations, the lawyers, the western physicians, the money people, etc.

The biggest mistake we made over all was we didn't gain self-awareness and then act. We didn't learn about ourselves. We didn't understand that we are all connected. We took extreme positions of right and wrong. We didn't have insight into ourselves, so we reluctantly joined those institutions and didn't know that we had those aspects within ourselves. We know that now.

We need what Debra Meyerson calls Tempered Radicalism. To be a tempered radical means being both an insider and outsider. It's about rocking the boat but not so hard that you fall out of it. It is a balancing act. Small changes through right action and a clear mind

increase your sense of efficacy. This process begins with action rather than analysis.

Small actions, like the flap of butterfly wings or kindness can provoke change from many places within organizations. One small action at a time. One relationship at a time. One short moment of connection.

I would like to end by reading a bit by Pema Chodren in the commencement address she gave to the graduating class at Naropa in 2014.

Your Story

For over 25 years, Judith Orloff has dedicated her life to helping people transform their perspectives, allowing them to see through judgements, assumptions and the brilliantly constructed walls we build around ourselves. Doing so empowers us to make clearer decisions and create new possibilities for ourselves. She has worked with individuals, corporations, universities, and families, and her work continues to create meaning for participants long after the programs are complete.

Using her Six Principles of Emotional Literacy, Judith has developed a core learning methodology so fundamental that it has been used successfully in a diverse range of applications: strategic learning initiatives for Fortune 500 companies, aligning executive teams, healing family and individual trauma, and personal transformation. Radical Choices is the next stage in the evolution of Judith's teaching. As we move through a rapidly-changing world of technology and interconnectivity, our company seeks to address the needs and concerns of today's world through today's medium: smartphones and tablets.

Social Movements

Environmentalism had its origins in the 1970's with the first Earth Day being held on April 22, 1970.

2nd-wave feminist movement in the US took a prominent role within society, the Supreme Court's 1973 decision of *Roe v. Wade* that constitutionalized the right to an abortion brought the women's rights movement into the national political spotlight. The wage gap failed to close but progress was made in lessening the gap.

The gay movement made a huge step forward in the 1970s with the election of political figures such as Harvey Milk to public office and the advocating of anti-gay discrimination legislation passed and not passed during the decade. Many celebrities, including Freddie Mercury and Andy Warhol, also "came out" during this decade, bringing gay culture further into the limelight.

The Black Nationalist movement grew out of frustrations with the "non-violent" strategies of earlier Civil Rights Activists. With the assassinations of both Martin Luther King, Jr. and Senator Bobby Kennedy, many blacks were compelled to reject ideas of negotiation and instead embrace isolation. The feminist movement also splintered from a larger push for Civil Rights in the 1970s.

John Dewey

The overriding theme of Dewey's works was his profound belief in democracy, be it in politics, education or communication and journalism. As Dewey himself stated in 1888, while still at the University of Michigan, "Democracy and the one, ultimate, ethical ideal of humanity are to my mind synonymous."

The ideas of democracy and social reform are continually discussed in Dewey's writings on education. Dewey makes a strong case for the importance of education

not only as a place to gain content knowledge, but also as a place to learn how to live. In his eyes, the purpose of education should not revolve around the acquisition of a pre-determined set of skills, but rather the realization of one's full potential and the ability to use those skills for the greater good.

"education is a regulation of the process of coming to share in the social consciousness; and that the adjustment of individual activity on the basis of this social consciousness is the only sure method of social reconstruction".

Dewey advocated for an educational structure that strikes a balance between delivering knowledge while also taking into account the interests and experiences of the student.

"the child and the curriculum are simply two limits which define a single process. Just as two points define a straight line, so the present standpoint of the child and the facts and truths of studies define instruction"

Children enter education with 4 innate impulses; To communicate, to construct, to inquire and to express in finer form.

Tempered Radical

"Tempered radicals" may not sound like the type to start revolutions or topple corrupt governments, but in the corporate world, it is often these quiet change advocates that get the ball rolling and policies changing".

It's being both an insider and an outsider, working to fit into what is currently acceptable and working to change norms of acceptability. It's about rocking the boat, but not so hard that you fall out of it. So tempered radicalism is in many ways a balancing act that gets expressed in a variety of ways.

Asserting the nonconforming aspects of oneself can pave the way for learning and change by questioning current practice and expectations and providing an alternative. ... When people act in ways that outwardly express a valued part of their selves, they make that part of their selves 'real.'

Another view sees organizations as organic and evolutionary, which means they are changing all the time. If we think of organizations that way, little nudges in the system can change the network of relationships, stimulate learning, and affect how work gets done. It means that small actions actually matter and that people can provoke change from many places within the organization.

When actions produce a concrete result, they increase a person's sense of efficacy, which in turn fuels new efforts and a different perspective on what constitutes an opportunity for making change. Success fuels involvement, and involvement fuels more action, and so on. The process begins, though, with action rather than analysis.